



Digital Faith: Opportunities and Challenges in Freedom of Religion in The Philippines' AI Generation

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Artificial intelligence (AI) is set to emerge as the main force behind transformation. Essentially, AI involves computer systems capable of handling sophisticated tasks typically requiring human intelligence such as: reasoning, making decisions, and creating. Furthermore, AI's evolution has brought about many targeted advantages in every sector. Because artificial intelligence performs best with optimized data, ensuring data quality is now critically important. However, to innovate responsibly with this data, the AI systems must be trustworthy, meaning they need to be ethical, fair, and sustainable in their design and use.¹

At present, the rapid development of artificial intelligence has reached even the different religious sectors in the Philippines. While the 1987 Constitution guarantees the freedom of religion as outlined in Article III, Section 5,² the intersection of these two areas presents both opportunities for religious communities and challenges to religious freedom.

Ministries today face a growing demand for inclusive communication that reaches everyone. To meet this need, they require a varied set of tools to ensure their message is accessible to a wider audience. AI can significantly broaden the reach, accessibility, and inclusivity of religious teachings across the globe. By promoting and enhancing personal spiritual growth through applications that provide daily devotions, bible verses, and meditations. Such accessible and often personalized content directly to users' devices empowers individuals to engage with their faith more regularly and deeply, fostering a more consistent and enriched journey of spiritual development. It can facilitate the worldwide spread of spiritual messages through translations of sermons, help with the creation of religious content, and enhance the experience of online worship.³

¹ SAS: Data and AI Solutions, *Artificial Intelligence: what it is and why it matters*, https://www.sas.com/en_ph/insights/analytics/what-is-artificial-intelligence.html

² The 1987 Constitution of The Republic of The Philippines. <https://lawphil.net/consti/cons1987.html>

³ The Role of AI In Enhancing Church Accessibility and Inclusion, Aberdeen Broadcast Services



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One of AI's major advantages is its ability to take existing content and adapt it for different formats or audiences. For ministries, this means AI can be a powerful tool to transform written sermon transcripts into engaging blog posts or meaningful devotional readings. It can also help condense longer messages into concise social media snippets, perfect for sharing. Furthermore, AI offers the ability to tailor teaching materials to suit diverse age groups or different learning preferences, making spiritual education more accessible and impactful for everyone.⁴

It is also important to recognize its limitations. When an AI algorithm is trained using data that doesn't fully represent diverse groups, its results will inevitably carry those same biases. If an AI algorithm displays bias, catering more to a particular religion, this would present discrimination towards other religions leading to exclusion in some services. This bias might appear to stem from flawed algorithms or issues with how data is gathered and filtered. However, the root cause often lies in the unacknowledged biases of the development team itself. If these biases, already present in the training datasets, aren't properly addressed, the AI could end up producing distorted interpretations of religious teachings. This, in turn, risks reinforcing harmful stereotypes and making it harder for different faiths to truly understand each other.⁵ Consequently, this could violate their fundamental rights to non-discrimination and equal protection as they practice their religious freedom.

Another significant risk is the ability of AI to be manipulated. Artificial intelligence has a broad training approach that enables generative AI to provide insights and generate content that reflects a more accurate and diverse picture of global religious practices and the state of religious freedom. Users interacting with these AI models can ask questions and receive information, that may be suppressed in their own countries, thus gaining access to a wider understanding of religious issues.⁶ However, if these religious contents are tampered with using artificial intelligence, it could rapidly spread misinformation, or promote fake sermons, messages, or other content

⁴ The Malphurs Group, *Good AI vs. Bad AI: Ethical Ways for Churches to Use Artificial Intelligence*, <https://malphursgroup.com/good-ai-vs-bad-ai-ethical-ways-for-churches-to-use-artificial-intelligence/?hl=en-PH>

⁵ Zhang et al. (2025, May 5). *Cognitive bias in generative AI influences religious education*. National Library of Medicine, <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12053680/?hl=en-PH>

⁶ Abdelnour, K. (2024). *Generative AI: A double-edged sword for religious freedom and human rights*. <https://www.irfoundtable.org/intern-insights-blog/generative-ai>



that appears to come from a legitimate religious authority. This deceptive content has the potential to spark conflict between different religious groups and severely mislead individuals in their faith.

Given AI's powerful capabilities, there's a significant risk that the data it collects could be leveraged in ways that are detrimental to its users. AI systems collect data from various sources, many of which involve collecting data from consumers without their knowledge or consent. This extensive collection often includes personal information about a person that can be linked either directly or indirectly back to them. Such identifiable data can encompass a wide range of details, from an individual's full name and physical address to their date of birth and many other pieces of information that, when combined, can uniquely identify them.⁷ The accumulation of such personal data by AI systems, often obtained without express consent, constitutes a direct infringement upon individuals' fundamental right to privacy.

When people become aware or even suspect that their deeply held religious beliefs, practices, or affiliations are under constant surveillance and analysis by these advanced technological systems, it inevitably fosters a profound sense of apprehension. This fear of being monitored can, in turn, create a chilling effect on their willingness to openly express their faith. They might hesitate to engage in public acts of worship, participate in religious discussions online, or even voice their spiritual convictions privately, out of concern that such expressions could be recorded, profiled, or potentially used against them. This atmosphere of surveillance can thus subtly, yet powerfully, suppress the vibrant exercise of religious freedom, forcing individuals to self-censor their spiritual lives to avoid perceived scrutiny or potential adverse consequences.

Moreover, due to AI's convenience, it can create dependence or over-reliance. This excessive dependence on artificial intelligence for deeply personal aspects of faith, such as receiving spiritual guidance, interpreting profound scripture, or even engaging in worship, presents a significant concern. Such over-reliance carries the risk of fundamentally diminishing the very essence of religious experience, particularly its crucial personal, communal, and human interactions, which are universally acknowledged as central to the authenticity of most, if not all, religious traditions. This raises

⁷ Osano (January 2025), *AI and Data Privacy: Exploring the privacy risks in the era of artificial intelligence*, <https://www.osano.com/articles/ai-and-data-privacy?hl=en-PH>



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profound questions regarding the genuine exercise of one's religious profession. In an individual's spiritual journey, the very nature of their faith practice could be fundamentally altered due to varied circumstances. These practices of faith include their understanding of divine texts or their participation in sacred rituals. Such are reshaped when these practices increasingly become filtered, mediated, or even dictated by complex algorithms rather than springing from their own deeply held personal conviction, internal reflection, and active communal engagement with fellow believers. This shift could potentially lead to a less authentic, more detached form of religious expression, challenging the traditional ways in which faith is lived, shared, and nurtured within human communities.

In summary, while Artificial Intelligence presents powerful new tools that hold significant promise for enriching religious practices and strengthening community bonds across the Philippines, its remarkably swift and expansive development brings with it a crucial responsibility. This rapid progress makes it absolutely essential for us to establish and implement proactive ethical guidelines and robust legal frameworks. The primary purpose of these frameworks is to ensure that AI technologies are always developed and used in a manner that genuinely respects and actively upholds the fundamental constitutional guarantee of religious freedom, which is enshrined in the Philippine Constitution. Without such careful foresight and clear regulations, there is a distinct risk that AI, despite its potential benefits, could inadvertently or even deliberately become a mechanism that undermines or infringes upon this vital right. Therefore, a balanced and thoughtful approach is paramount to harness AI's potential while safeguarding deeply held liberties.



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